

England Almost Lost to a Tiny Nation -- Until Harry Kane Saved the Day

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Can you imagine one of the world's best soccer teams almost losing to a country most people can't find on a map? That nearly happened to England! They were playing **DR Congo**, a team ranked much lower, and with only 15 minutes left, England was about to be knocked out of the World Cup. It would have been one of the biggest **embarrassments** in their history.

But then, superstar Harry Kane stepped up. He scored two late goals to give England a 2-1 win and a spot in the next round. Phew! The whole team and their coach, Thomas Tuchel, breathed a huge sigh of relief. If they had lost, it would have been as shocking as when England lost to Iceland years ago.

Now England faces a huge challenge: they play Mexico in Mexico City, at the famous **Azteca Stadium**. The crowd will be wild, and the pressure will be on. But England has some big problems to fix. They depend way too much on Kane and another star, Jude Bellingham. Other players need to step up. The defense is messy, especially the **right-back** position four different players have tried it, and even a **midfielder** ended up there! Coach Tuchel keeps changing the **lineup**, and it's not clear he knows his best team.

Kane and Bellingham are amazing, but they can't do it all alone. If England wants to beat Mexico and go further, they need everyone to play their part. Otherwise, their World Cup dream could end in heartbreak.

Word Treasure

DR Congo -- Short for Democratic Republic of the Congo, a country in Africa with a men's national soccer team.

embarrassment -- The feeling when something makes you look silly or ashamed.

Azteca Stadium -- A huge stadium in Mexico City where many important soccer matches have been played.

right-back -- The player on the back line who defends the right side of the field.

midfielder -- A player who works in the middle of the field, helping both defense and attack.

lineup -- The official list of players who start the game and where they stand.

Background you need

In soccer, sometimes smaller teams surprise big ones. In 2016, England lost to Iceland in the European Championship, a huge upset. DR Congo (a country in Central Africa) is ranked far below England, so almost losing to them would have been just as embarrassing. The Azteca Stadium in Mexico City is famous for its huge crowds and high altitude, which makes it a tough place to play.

Break it down

WHO: The England soccer team, star players Harry Kane and Jude Bellingham, and coach Thomas Tuchel.

WHAT: England nearly suffered a shocking loss to low-ranked DR Congo, but two late goals by Kane rescued a 2-1 victory.

WHERE: A World Cup match (implied in the U.S./Canada) and then the upcoming knockout game at Azteca Stadium in Mexico City.

WHY: The team is struggling because it relies too heavily on two stars; the defense is disorganized, and coach Tuchel keeps changing the lineup, raising doubts about their chances.

Why it matters

Even star players need their teammates to help, just like in a school project where everyone must do their part for success.

Test what you remember

1. Who was England playing when they almost got knocked out?

- ☐ (A) Mexico
- ☐ (B) DR Congo
- ☐ (C) Iceland
- ☐ (D) Portugal

2. How many goals did Harry Kane score?

- ☐ (A) 1
- ☐ (B) 2
- ☐ (C) 3
- ☐ (D) 4

3. Where will England play their next match?

- ☐ (A) Azteca Stadium in Mexico City
- ☐ (B) Wembley Stadium in London
- ☐ (C) Toronto Stadium
- ☐ (D) Kansas City Stadium

4. Who is England's coach?

- ☐ (A) Harry Kane
- ☐ (B) Jude Bellingham
- ☐ (C) Thomas Tuchel
- ☐ (D) Pep Guardiola

5. What position has seen four different players?

- ☐ (A) Striker
- ☐ (B) Goalkeeper
- ☐ (C) Right-back
- ☐ (D) Left-wing

6. Who else does England rely on besides Kane?

- ☐ (A) Marcus Rashford
- ☐ (B) Jude Bellingham
- ☐ (C) Phil Foden
- ☐ (D) Declan Rice

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: C 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **England fans:** They are thrilled to advance, but they know the team has serious problems that a stronger opponent like Mexico could exploit.
2. **Coach Thomas Tuchel:** He must figure out the best lineup and get more players to contribute, or England's World Cup dream could end early.
3. **DR Congo supporters:** Even in defeat, they are proud because their team came so close to beating a soccer giant, showing that any team can be competitive.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):